Hands Still Raised – A Program

with poems by Jasmine Mans and Andrea Gibson

Orlando by Andrea Gibson

(Pg 11-15) When the first responders

entered the Pulse nightclub

after the massacre in Orlando,

they walked through the horrific scene

of bodies and called out,

"If you are alive, raise your hand."

I was sleeping in a hotel

in the Midwest at the time,

but I imagine in that exact moment,

my hand twitched in my sleep,

some unconscious part of me aware

that I had a pulse

that I was alive . . . .

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INTRODUCTION

Standing at the intersection of the LBGTQ community, faith, fury and grief, these poems refuse silence. They wrestle with a God shaped by human prejudice, with trans bodies treated as battlegrounds, and with the echo of gunfire still ricocheting from the Pulse Nightclub after the Orlando shooting. What does it mean to survive in a world that confuses love with sin and visibility with danger? This collection is an urgent call to raise our hands; to insist that humanity must be bigger than cruelty and that no one should have to hide who they truly are.

Hands Still Raised – A program including Maybe We Can fool God and Trans-panic by Jasmine Mans and Orlando by Andrea Gibson

Maybe We Can Fool God by Jasmine Mans

(Pg 86-67) When a transwoman

is murdered

no one cares,

because we assume

God doesn't either.

Maybe being a transwoman

feels like an endless game

of hide-and-seek with God.

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Maybe God only knows us
by our flesh.

Maybe we've made of our God
a wandering man,
with only our birth name
and baby photo.

One who hasn't already measured
the lineage of our selfhood,
maybe He's our fool.

Maybe when
a boy
becomes
a girl,
she fools God.

Fools Him good
so good,
that he wouldn't be able to find her,
wouldn't be able to recognize her
amongst the rest of us sinners.

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Trans-Panic by Jasmine Mans

(Pg 88-89) I've heard of men who grip
and gargle foreign, yet
familiar, body parts, then
know not what to make of
their hands, but murder.

Lynching their lovers,
then abandoning their bodies
in unlocked motel rooms.

Trying to kill off
a part of themselves,
that has been left
a whisper.

I once read of a woman
who spilled of herself
a reddish bouquet.

Who was stabbed, so
many times, in her chest
it almost looked as
if someone was

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trying to get away
with her heart.

She was found
with duct tape
over her mouth
so she wouldn't
be able to tell
the whole story,
or, the love
story.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jasmine Mans
Book: Black Girl, Call Home, Pg 86-89
ISBN: 978-0593197141
Publisher: Berkley
Date (Month/Year): Mar 2021

Orlando by Andrea Gibson

(con't) . . . The next day I woke to the news
that an assault rifle had fired
202 bullets through a gay bar
on Latin night in one of the worst
massacres in US history -- a massacre

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of people who did not leave the dance floor
when they heard gunshots
because they thought
they were just the beats
of the song.

Everyone around me spent
that day grieving and every tear
tasted like dance sweat
drying in the morgue.

Later that night
I was performing for an audience
that had spent two hours in line
waiting to get through bag checks
and metal detectors. On stage
I couldn't keep my hand
from covering

my heart. Kept searching
the club for the fastest route
to every exit. I knew the person
working security was in a text war
and wasn't keeping his eyes

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on the door; I knew there was a man
in the fifth row picking at the seams
of a red duffel bag.

Every few seconds
I'd eye the balcony
for the glint
of whatever might aim
to tear the bodies
off the boys holding hands
or the girls with the haircuts short
as my temper when rage
is a decibel I can actually get to
when I not just frozen
and grief-sick watching history

not be history, watching
the music not be music, knowing
someone having the best night of her life
shouted, ***This is my favorite song,***
and then a drumbeat lifted

a rifle over a bathroom stall
and emptied a magazine

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into the kidneys of a grown man
texting, ***Mommy I'm going to die***,
his handprints in blood
on the walls, reaching

for people
dying in the fetal position.
People covered in their friend's blood,
crying too hard to hide
from their own deaths,
people outside pushing
bandannas into bullet wounds.

It's true
what they say about the gays
being so fashionable --
our ghosts never go
out of style.

even life is like funeral practice:
half of us already dead
to our families before we die.
half of us on our knees

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trying to crawl
into the family photo.

That night on stage I kept remembering
being fifteen at Disney World
wearing my best friend's hoodie

like it was my boyfriend's
class ring.

How many years it took me
to just touch her face.
how many years of praying
my heart could play dead
until the threat was gone
until the world changed

until history was history,
but history just keeps coming
for the high, keeps shooting up
bodies, keeps drumming up reasons

to have metal detectors
at poetry readings
where the poems feel

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like unanswered calls
to people who claim their god
or their apathy, is unwilling
to accept the charges.

Dear god, how broke
do you have to be
to not buy people time
to get out the door
when the song
goes to f****** hell?

When this world, drunk
on hate, decides blood
is wine and drinks its fill
in the only place
they ever thought was safe?
In the only place they thought
they didn’t have to hide?

In the only place they were wanted
because of who they loved
and how they loved
and how they loved

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until someone walked through their bodies

and asked who was still alive

and hardly anyone

put their hand up. *(raise hand slowly)*

(From the Intro) Humanity must be bigger than cruelty.
No one should have to hide who they truly are.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
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AWARD HISTORY

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